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John Best

Trumpeter Johnny Best was born on October 30, 1913 in Shelby, North Carolina. By the time he was a teenager, John was playing dances around his home and developing a trumpet style that would enable him to play in the brass sections of the top big bands of the Swing Era. After stints with Les Brown and Charlie Barnet, he joined Artie Shaw in 1937, later playing with the Glenn Miller Orchestra during their most popular years. John has worked with Benny Goodman and Bob Crosby as well as in the studios of the west coast. A debilitating accident did not silence his trumpet and he participated in reunion tours of the Miller and Crosby bands in the '80s. John lives in the San Diego area and he can be seen performing with his friend, clarinetist Bobby Gordon.

John was interviewed in San Diego, California on February 15, 1998, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe, and we are filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive in San Diego, California, and I am very, very pleased to have Johnny Best, big band trumpeter and notable musician throughout many, many years of American music. Thank you so much for joining me today.

JB: Well thank you for having me.

MR: As I told you before the cameras were rolling, I have this idea that the big band days, that the Swing Era was a great time to be a young man. Was that a fair statement?

JB: Well, people seemed to be pretty happy then, with that kind of music.

MR: What was it about that kind of music that made it so popular?

JB: That's a hard one. Well basically it was dance music, and of course the country was full of ballrooms in those days, and people liked to dance. Ballroom dance. And I think that was, between the ballrooms and the theaters, that was what they liked.

MR: When you were a young man, oh well let's say a boy, what attracted you to the trumpet?

JB: I'm not sure, oh, I'll tell you how it started.

MR: Sure.

JB: And it goes back to 1926. My brother brought a cornet home from the public schools and I picked it up one day and it had a little book with the fingering on it and I could play "My Country Tis of Thee." Well it wound up that I took the cornet. The music professor needed a trombone player, and he switched my brother to trombone. And that's how I started with the cornet, with the school cornet. And probably about four or five months later the music man, the band master, suggested to my dad that he buy me a good trumpet, because I had improved enough. So he did, he bought me a silver plated Buescher trumpet, for $52, in 1927. Gold plated bell. And that's how I started, and I stuck with the trumpet.

MR: You played in the school band and learned to read music from that?

JB: Right. Well, when I was six years old, my mother had me take piano lessons, and I don't know whether it was fortunate or unfortunate, but the older boys, they made fun of me, for I was the only boy in the small town that played piano. And they said nobody but sissies and girls played piano. So that was the end of my piano. And I regretted that some years later.

MR: Yeah, piano can be a great thing to know.

JB: Even chords on it.

MR: Can you recall the first recordings you heard in the jazz field that made you take some notice?

JB: Well in this band later on, we'll say 1927, '28, we didn't even have a radio in the house, in our house until 1928. So about four houses up the street, the saxophone player who played in the band, he was three years older, and I'd go up there and listen to the radio, and he had some recordings of Coon-Sanders, and on the radio we'd just pick out — well that band was also on the radio, WGN in Chicago.

MR: They would play the music of the day, which was jazz?

JB: Right, I can't remember. But Paul Whiteman in 1928 did a concert in Charlotte, which was about 50 miles away. And I went over to that concert. And Bix Beiderbecke was in the band, and Frankie Trumbauer and Bing Crosby and Henry Busse. And Henry Busse made more of an impression than Bix did at that time.

MR: No kidding. Did he have maybe a bigger sound or something?

JB: Well maybe he was just a better salesman. But I think I was 15 years old then. But I went off to college, and after the first year of college I wound up in a band, an organized band, and led by a woman, Olga Burns. And we had a trombone player in that band that brought in some arrangements that Red Nichols had played, and he was a Miff Mole fan. And so I learned a few things. In fact, in that summer he came in with whatever the magazine was about music and entertainment, it said Bix Beiderbecke had died, and showed me the article. And of course I said, "Bix who?" He said, "The greatest trumpet player that ever lived." So that became my — I went out and bought some Beiderbecke records that he was on. I didn't buy the original stuff, which I should have, but I bought some Whiteman records that Beiderbecke had played some.

MR: He's looked on as almost a legend now, Bix. And so was he really popular in the 20s also? But you hadn't heard of him really until he died. Is that right?

JB: Right, but I had heard him play and didn't know it. But I was impressed with a record that he made, he played some background on the Paul Whiteman record of "Melancholy Baby" that Jack Fulton sang. And that's why — the first time I heard him play and I was

very impressed by the little thing he did behind the vocal, not realizing that those were the two that I saw at that concert. I didn't know their names.

MR: Did your parents, were they supportive of your interest in music as you grew up? Or did they want you to be something else?

JB: My mother wanted me to be a preacher. I think my dad — whatever I did I was his favorite. But the way it turned out, it just kept working. I never studied music you know. I always regretted that. But I liked to play and I just liked songs, you know, and it kept going. We never made any money. If we did make it, the leader would go off with it in those days. I remember we did a whole bunch of college stuff, Christmas holidays, in North Carolina and Virginia. And this guy took all the money. The next time we saw him he's smoking an expensive cigar and has a beautiful suit of clothes.

MR: And you paid for it.

JB: We paid for it.

MR: What band was that? Was that one of the early groups?

JB: That was a band that originated at the University of North Carolina. That's where I went after my freshman year in college of Davison. I transferred there — because they had a much bigger school there, they also had a music school, which I didn't go. But they had campus bands, like that's where Hal Kemp first started. And it's also where Kay Kyser came from. And more opportunity to play. By this time I really wanted to play, and on the campus, when I transferred there as a sophomore, there was a trumpet — the band was The Carolina Tarheels they called them. And they had a trumpet player, Bix Ramsey. So I asked him, I said, "Why do they call you Bix?" He said, "Because I play so much like Bix." He was kind of a — I won't say dumb — but he was a good player, and funny. He wrote out some stuff that Bix played, note for note, and I finally played in that band with him, and we dropped out of school several times. And that's how it just kept going like that.

MR: Did you kind of give up college to go out and pursue your music?

JB: I gave up college for three years when I was in bands, and then I went back to college for another, well I guess a full year. And by that time, well I never did go back to get a degree, because I had music jobs that I wanted to keep playing, ones from unknown bands, to, I wound up, some fellow had a band in 1936. Normally you would know about Hank Biagini — well Hank Biagini was from Detroit and he had the original Casa Loma band, which was actually Jean Goldkette — that name?

MR: Sure.

JB: Well Goldkette had a band called the Orange Blossoms, and Biagini took over that band and played cornet, not a jazz band. That band actually became the Casa Loma band, which was under Glen Gray, about 1931 or '32. And I wound up in New York and some

band broke up and went out of New York with the Biagini band. He was playing one of the ballrooms, The Paragon I think — or that sounds like Chicago — but in New York. I went out with that band, $25 a week, 1932 or 3. '33 yeah. But we made it, you know.

MR: If you got $25 a week, did you have to pay for your rooms?

JB: Rooms, food. Yeah. Milk was eight cents a quart.

MR: Did you sent any money home?

JB: A dime was a tip. If you went out with your girl, twenty-five cents was a good tip. They had Horn and Hardart, you know the restaurant, where nickels and quarters were the biggest thing, and they had excellent quality food, in New York.

MR: You put a thing in the machine?

JB: Yeah. A slot. And you'd get a meal for twenty-five, thirty-five cents.

MR: Wow. So you could live on $25 a week if you were a young man.

JB: Yeah.

MR: You did, obviously.

JB: I got a raise up to $40 and I thought I was in—

MR: And when you guys went out to travel, did you mostly take two or three cars? Or was it on a bus? A train?

JB: Cars. Yeah, it would be cars in those days, yeah. I remember with Biagini we left I think it was Erie, Pennsylvania — cold — and went to Binghamton. That's when, I got out of that car, we checked in the hotel, and I saw this thermometer, 28 below zero. And I was dumb enough just to walk out and go the restaurant. Your ears could have dropped off I think.

MR: Your trumpet could stick to your mouth at those temperatures.

JB: Yeah, and I also had just the opposite of that once, in Guadalcanal, where you had to shade the mouthpiece from the sun. That was during the Navy.

MR: We're going to get to that, remind me, and I'll ask you about that. Les Brown, Charlie Barnet? Were these the first let's say name groups?

JB: Well, go back to 1932. I had dropped out of school, and in North Carolina it was on a quarter system instead of the semester. I dropped out after the second quarter. And around Greensboro I just played with bands. And I think it was in May of that year I got a call from the leader of the Duke University Blue Devils band. They had two bands on the campus there. And this was before Les. And wanted to know if I would do a summer job with them in Lancaster, Pennsylvania, which I did, I took the job. And that band, after the summer job was booked by MCA for three weeks in New England under the Sherman brothers ballrooms. Nick Laney, the star football player at Duke was the leader. We got to Boston and there was a band there from Harrisburg, Pennsylvania, and Les Brown was in that band. They heard him play and talked Les into going — he had just finished high

school — into going to Duke that fall, which he did. And I also enrolled in Duke that fall. And I stayed there six weeks and left again. But Les graduated from Duke four years later. In the meantime I went back to Chapel Hill, ten miles away, at the University, the campus. And I was playing with Les' band and also a campus band, and that was the end of my schooling after that. I wound up going to Chicago in 1936 with some fellows that I had met with the Biagini band in Savannah, Georgia, to Tybee Beach, Hank Biagini had a band down there. And I came down to join the band, but I had laid off for three weeks and I had no endurance. So I didn't get the job. It didn't make any difference, because I just had laid off three weeks. But I met all those guys. And this was a band that I got — they were the nucleus of a band that was organized in Chicago that fall. That would be 1936. And this guy was from Wheeling, Pennsylvania, and he wound up as a radio announcer, Hugh McPherson was his name. And he organized this band. It was a pretty good band. It was reviewed, we played The Meadowbrook, Frank Dailey's Meadowbrook. I got an honorable mention write-up by George Simon, and Glenn Miller was with George Simon and they came in there and that was the first time I'd met Glenn. I had heard him before and seen him before. But they heard me play and it was favorable mention.

MR: Your first time in print?

JB: What?

MR: Your first time that your name showed up in print as far as the music magazine?

JB: Yeah. And that band broke up at the end of '36. So I decided I'd try to get a New York card. You have to sit out six months time, residence. You are eligible to work after three months, certain type of work. So you've got to sweat it out. Well I was sweating it out for three months. And I got a knock on the door and a trumpet player that I had played with with Biagini, in Savannah, and also in the McPherson band, he had Artie Shaw with him. Well I had heard of Artie Shaw, in fact I had a record that I had bought of Artie Shaw, with strings on it, and Peg LaCentra sang the vocal on it. And a song called "I'll Remember" I think it was. And Artie said he was organizing a new band. And he had had string bands and a complete — lost a lot of money on it, because the people just wouldn't go for it. He was going to organize a band with the same instrumentation as Benny Goodman. And he had an opening for another trumpet. So I said well — maybe I shouldn't say all this, Artie might listen.

MR: Please, do.

JB: Anyway well I'll go ahead with it. I said, "Artie, I've been here three months, you know, starving. And I don't want to lose the three months time." He said, "I'm a personal friend of Jacob" — I don't remember his name, the President of the New York Local. He said, "I'll see that your time goes on.

MR: Because if you left New York, then you'd lose your three months? Is that the idea?

JB: Right. If they pull that card out, the union card out, your transfer card. So I said well that's fine you know. Well I'll make that short. At the end of the six months, I asked the manager for my card. He pulled it out and it said withdrawn, March 31st. So that kind of upset me a little bit. It was a while there that I was pretty angry at Mr. Shaw. And in September of that year I left Artie and I went back to North Carolina. I didn't have any job.

MR: So you never at that point got into the New York Local. Because they just pulled your card and you had to start over?

JB: Well in a way I'm glad I didn't. You know, because the way it turned out it was good. And you get mad — I got mad at Artie. He had a recording date and this was in the 1937 band, September. And I'd been in that band too. But after the union card thing, I was not too friendly. So he had one of those transcription dates in New York. Like we'd play in Wildwood, New Jersey, a summer resort, and this was September I guess, at the end of the summer. And there was a new tune out, I can't remember the name of it, and my part had the release on the tune. So I played it, and the saxophone player, a good friend, Freddie Petrie, he turned around and gave me the, "Yeah!" you know, encouraging. I got through, sat down, and at the end of the thing Shaw said, "John, is that the best you can play that?" I said, "Artie" — at that time it was my best attempt. He said "I'll play that tomorrow on the recording." And I said, "Well, as of right now, Artie, you can play every other solo I have in the book." And that kind of shook him up. He said, "Well what does that mean?" I said, "Two weeks or tonight, any way you want, either way I'll leave tonight." And I did leave in two weeks. I went back to North Carolina. Eight months, I worked in a furniture store and did local, you know, playing around Charlotte, Spartanburg, and a couple of colleges there. Eight months, and Artie had told me and some of those guys that I didn't hear enough of the early Louis Armstrongs, which I didn't. And meantime I had bought a lot of those records and listened to them and I finally realized what they were talking about. Like "Wild Man Blues" and all those old things. So I wrote Artie a letter somewhere in that time. He called me up and said, "Do you want to come back?" So I did, I went back to join him in Boston, to Roseland Square Ballroom I think. Billie Holiday was in the band. And I stayed in that band until I joined the Glenn Miller band. Three years, three or more years.

MR: You did some traveling in the south with Artie Shaw? When Billie Holiday was in the band, didn't you?

JB: Yeah. Not much. There was one incident that — Billie used to ride in my car, with Zutty Singleton also, who traveled with the band for a while in the summer of 1938. And we were in Ohio or someplace. But we went into West Virginia. And Zutty knew the area,

Parkersburg, West Virginia. I'd never been. So he told me where to stop, and there was a nice looking building, a three story building. And it was a hotel, but it was for black people. And he got out, and he said, "Billie, you'd better get out." And she said, "No." She said, "I'm going down with the rest of the guys." He said, "You'll be sorry. You're down south." And she muttered a few words. Anyway we went on down to the hotel and they said, "We're all full" to her you know. So she got back in the car and I took her back to the hotel. That was one incident. But there were others, even in New England of all places.

MR: No kidding.

JB: Yeah. There were some cracks made when she walked into a dining room.

MR: Did she have to come in through the kitchen door sometimes? That kind of thing?

JB: Oh that part, you're talking about the Lincoln Hotel in New York. I mean that's where that — the bandstand at the Lincoln Hotel was facing the audience and the ballroom floor. To the right was a door to the kitchen at the other end of the bandstand. And all the tables and stuff were out in front. And the other entranceway, that was the Lincoln Hotel, and we had to come through the kitchen. Otherwise you're walking right down through the — and we were used to that. I don't know exactly what happened there, but maybe it was because Helen did not come through the kitchen — Helen Forrest — she was in the band with Billie. I think that would be right there, what that was.

MR: Right, okay. I wanted to ask you something, you were taking about listening to Louis Armstrong, and that you considered those records to be older stuff, that you had to go back and listen to. But this was late 1930s you were talking about, right? And Louis had recorded those records only about ten years before that. Is that right? So it really wasn't that big a space between the time when you had to go back and listen to him, it was only ten years, is that right? So really it kind of wasn't that old.

JB: Well what kind of burned those guys up a little bit, the ones that were talking about the old Louis, my favorite trumpet player by that time was Bunny Berigan. He was my idol. And when I heard Bunny I just said well that's it. But Bunny's favorite was Louis. And that's what they told me, they said, "Where do you think he learned to play from?" So you learn, a little bit at a time.

MR: Well you were getting your Louis through Bunny, then, right?

JB: Well I liked Beiderbecke too. But Louis always, when I listened to his old records, it's amazing. And also Jack Teagarden. Probably of all the musicians that I ever listened to of course Louis and Jack Teagarden would probably be the top of my list, those guys.

MR: Did you become known as a lead player or as a hot man, or somewhere in between?

JB: Well I guess one of the compliments that I ever had, said during the war when they were drafting people, they said well I could, you know if you had to get down to one guy, I

would be the one, because I could do a little bit of each. I never had a real strong, you know, high notes, until after all the bands were through, and then I had my own group. Then I could play. But there was always somebody in that band that wanted to out-do you. Four trumpets wanted to blow you off the stand.

MR: Well tell me how your years with Glenn Miller came about.

JB: I'm sorry?

MR: Tell me how you got started with Glenn Miller. Was it 1939?

JB: Yeah. Well I left the Shaw band in August 1939. There was something personal going on that I'd rather not talk about. But I was looking for a job. In other words, I got my notice from Shaw. I'm not afraid to say it. But it didn't have anything to do with — well I can't even say that.

MR: It wasn't a musical thing.

JB: Well he did suggest that I get a smaller bore horn. He thought my tone didn't blend with Chuck Peterson and Bernie Privin. But there was more to this than I can talk about, involving another sex.

MR: Hmmm let's see.

JB: Okay. I hope you can —

MR: Sure, we can read between the lines on that.

JB: Anyway, I was looking for a job, and we were at the hotel in Boston, I can't remember, some plaza in Boston. So I came to New York on a day off. I talked to George Simon I guess. And I had called Benny Goodman and also Tommy Dorsey. No, I'm getting mixed up there at the end of the Miller thing, I'm sorry, that's not right. But I did — Simon said, the Glen Island Casino was on the route between Boston and New York, and I was driving. So on the way back to Boston, Simon recommended I talk to Glenn Miller. So I did. And that's where he hired me.

MR: Good timing, huh?

JB: He just had three trumpets. And I the added trumpet. He had offered me a job about a year before that. And so I joined the band in Washington, D.C. at the Capitol Theater.

MR: Now in that year, was it 1939 is that right?

JB: Yeah.

MR: If there were four top bands in the country, especially considered — if the musicians considered the four top bands, who would they have been in 1939? The four top bands.

JB: At that time? Who were they?

MR: Who were the really hot bands at that time?

JB: In '39?

MR: In 1939.

JB: Well that's when Miller actually came to the top. Shaw was still a hot band. Benny I guess had dropped some. I mean the swing bands. And of course you have Basie and Ellington, but they were always—

MR: Always there. So when you got hired on to Glenn Miller, what kind of salary did he offer you?

JB: Oh, it was a minimum thing I guess. I think it was $150 a week. I think.

MR: Was that a salary so no matter how many nights you played, you got the same amount of money?

JB: Well there was union scale for every job you play. There was a road scale for theaters and in those days it was $72 a week. You could play a hundred shows a week and you'd get $72. It wasn't good. If you were a star of course, you could demand your salary. But the Miller band never really had any salaried, like Benny — Benny paid Harry James $500 a week when I was making $40 a week or something. And Ziggy Elman and Krupa. But they were making — Miller was in debt when he first started his success, and paid that off. Actually the Shribman brothers had a contract with Miller for 33-1/3 percent.

MR: Wow.

JB: And I can remember Sy Shribman, when Miller made his, you know, was up, Shribman told Glenn he says, "That's a lot of money, isn't it Glenn?" You know he had a gravely voice. He says, "Well I'm going to let you out of that." And he did. He let him off the hook.

MR: That was pretty gentlemanly of him.

JB: Yeah it certainly was.

MR: And that name comes up a lot.

JB: Sy Shribman. Well Sy and Charlie and then another one, I can't think of his name, a nephew, handled one of the big singers I can't remember now but another Shribman. Out of Boston. Well they broke the Blue Devils. They were the ones — well we picked up Les Brown in Boston.

MR: Can you recall some of the Glenn Miller tunes that when you first played them, when the arrangements were first brought in, that the guys in the band were thinking, this is going to be a hot number? Were there any particular tunes that stood out?

JB: After I joined you mean?

MR: Yes.

JB: Well I can remember there was an arranger that brought tunes around after, when bands used to rehearse after, like two o'clock in the morning, you'd have a rehearsal after. He brought around an arrangement, which was "Tuxedo Junction." And they worked on it you know, and I think that turned out to be a tremendous hit.

MR: Who was the man who played the muted trumpet part in that song?

JB: Micky McMickle. Dale McMickle. Yeah. And Clyde Hurley played the open solo.

MR: That was an Erskine Hawkins thing, wasn't it?

JB: Yeah.

MR: Did he write the arrangement, or was it just his tune?

JB: Well this arrangement, Erskine Hawkins played a different line. His was more or less like a 32-bar tune, which is a standard, with a release. This was not quite like that. But it turned out to be a lot of repeats.

MR: Right. Did the — Glenn Miller and all those conductors had to really think about what kind of tempos were going to be good for the dancers, is that right?

JB: Say that again?

MR: They had to think about the people dancing to their music when they figured out how fast they wanted to play it?

JB: Shaw was more sensitive I believe like that. He never played anything really uptempo except for show reasons. I think the vocals, the lyrics would have to do with the tempo.

MR: Oh, that's true, yeah. Well what happened to you during the war years? What was your experience during World War II?

JB: Mine? Well I survived for one thing. I didn't want to get drafted. After the Miller band broke up, in September of '42, in Passaic, New Jersey, I joined the Bob Crosby band. And that lasted six weeks and that band broke up at that time. In the meantime during that period I got a call from Artie Shaw, that he was recruiting a band of professional musicians for the Navy. And their job would be to play for the troops, the military, as close to the action of the war as they would send us. And he told me who was in the band, he said Davy Tough, Max Kaminsky, Claude Thornhill and Sam Donahue. And it sounded like a good group, which it was, and meantime Miller had said he got a commission to go in the Army, and he got a Captain's commission and he had also said, "Don't do anything military until you get in touch with me." He said, "I am going to get a band in the military, or I am going to resign my commission." He was over age. Well and then I also had another thing from a band, a Navy band that said they would hold a place for me in Norfolk, Virginia. That was Saxie Dowell. I don't know whether that name rings a bill — he was a saxophone player with Hal Kemp for years, and he was in charge of this Navy band at Norfolk. And Dean Kincaid, a saxophone player, was in that band, a good friend. Well they came to New York one summer, the summer of '42, and they said they would hold a position for me until I made up my mind. So I actually had three ways — I didn't want to get drafted. There you have no choice. I had the attitude that if I could survive the war and still be able to make a living playing the horn, that's what I wanted to do. But if you go — I knew people, a good trumpet player that drove a tank — he never played the horn again the rest of his life. So I was fortunate enough to get with that band

and stay — Shaw was discharged. They threatened to break the band up then and send us out as replacements. But somebody in Washington said keep the group together, you've got an excellent group. So Sam Donahue was the leader. They sent us to England for a year, and that's where we had battle music with Glenn's Army band, on the Londonderry Club in London. The Queensbury Club, I said Londonderry, Queensbury.

MR: When you had a battle, each band played like a half hour or something, and the audience decided who they liked the best?

JB: The way it's set, I have a picture of it, the Miller band there were, they had 21 strings in it, and our band at this stage, we had an excellent band I mean musically — you couldn't — I still hear tapes of that Army band and musically it was ahead — well he had more choice, for selection. Where did we leave off?

MR: You were talking about the battle between Artie Shaw and Glenn Miller.

JB: Well that was Sam Donahue now.

MR: Oh, Sam Donahue, okay.

JB: After Shaw was discharged, after a year in the Pacific, and they threatened to break that band up and send us out as replacements. Now the other band that I had a choice of going with, they wound up on the Franklin Carrier which was blown off the map practically. It survived the bombing but they had eleven hundred casualties or something like that. I don't know about the band. I know Kincaid survived I know that, and so did the leader.

MR: So that turned out to be a pretty important decision you had made at that point.

JB: Well you can't—

MR: You can't look ahead and see that coming.

JB: Lucky, lucky.

MR: Did you get into Europe with the Donahue band?

JB: Before that band. After I mean I got into Europe with the Ray Conniff band you know. And also, South America.

MR: Well the Swing Era, I wanted to back track just a minute. When you joined Glenn Miller in '39, can you recall who else was in that band at that time?

JB: 1939?

MR: Yeah.

JB: The trumpets?

MR: Yeah.

JB: McMickle, Clyde Hurley and Lee Knowles. Lee was the head of Bulio Vineyards, a fine wine place. He died about, within the last year.

MR: No kidding. And was Tex Benecke?

JB: Tex was in the band. Al Klink, Willie Schwartz, Hal McIntyre. The drummer was Maurice Purtill, the bass player was Rolly Bundock. He was replaced by Trigger Alpert.

MR: Trigger Alpert, yeah.

JB: Who was replaced by Goldberg. Some of those guys were drafted, that's why they were replaced.

MR: What kind of man was Glenn Miller to work for?

JB: It depends on who you ask.

MR: Yeah? Well I'm asking you.

JB: Well he was a friend of mine. A lot of people did not like Glenn. But they had other reasons. And I had no reasons — it was a job. I got mad at him a few times, and he was a tough loser, if you got him in a craps game. He took it hard, to lose things.

MR: No kidding.

JB: And I don't know how much I should say about things like this, I really don't.

MR: Well I don't think it's going to harm any people, it's up to you.

JB: Because you can edit this out. Okay. Toward the end of the whole thing, the war was breaking up then. Harry James' popularity picked up considerably. It started off, you know they have the *DownBeat* poll and the *Metronome* poll. So every year it might change, and one guy will come up, like Benny Goodman was the big guy until Artie came up and went over the top. Artie was okay and then Glenn took over the top. And each time they'd do that, the leader, it affects them a little bit. So here we are with Glenn, and now Harry James is coming up. And actually Harry took over the Chesterfield broadcasts at that time. And of course Harry was tops, probably all during the war, as far as that type of band.

MR: But Glenn didn't like to be in second place, is that right?

JB: Well it's kind of a blow I guess.

MR: What kind of things would have got you fired from the Glenn Miller band?

JB: What kind?

MR: What kind of things would he have just said, "You're gone, you're out of here."

JB: I don't know.

MR: I mean if you showed up a half hour late.

JB: Oh, I see, yeah, that would be a no-no. Also, your dress, your clothing, and your appearance, and of course your drinking or whatever. One thing of course was marijuana, he'd fire a guy for that if it was known. Whiskey, you just had to hold it. I don't think, I don't remember seeing Glenn drink. He had some heavy drinkers, but unless they just couldn't do their job, they never got fired.

MR: When you'd go to do a recording session with Glenn or even with Artie Shaw, how much time did you usually have in the studio to do a side?

JB: Well a normal session was three hours. After that it's overtime. Ten dollars an hour.

MR: And how many tunes would you usually get done in three hours?

JB: As many as they could. I think there was eventually a limit on that, but there's been changes made. But you could do like two or three million-selling records and get ten dollars, your part.

MR: Oh, because you didn't get any residual or any of that kind of thing.

JB: No. They do today, but it's a little late for me.

MR: Tell me about, was it Bobby Hacket that played that trumpet solo on, I think it was "String of Pearls."

JB: "String of Pearls?" Yeah.

MR: You were on that record, yeah.

JB: Yeah.

MR: Did he just improvise that on the spot?

JB: Yes.

MR: It sounds like, it's such a nice solo, it almost sounds like someone sat down and wrote it out.

JB: Glenn, it was a Billy May solo with a plunger. And it didn't seem to fit the background. The trombones have a little background. So Glenn said, "Hey Bobby" — Bobby's playing guitar — he said, "You think you could fill in on that?" And he did and that's what came out. Bobby was a beautiful player, just great. And he knew chords and of course he was a guitar player. But he had excellent taste to me. I mean he belongs in the Teagarden class. He couldn't play the horn like Berigan, but what he did was just beautiful.

MR: Now it's interesting because if you buy the Glenn Miller arrangement of that song, they have his solo written out.

JB: Written out, yeah.

MR: It's like it's so perfect you have to do it.

JB: Yeah. I had to play it a lot of times. Well, I worked with Tex quite a bit, and the Modernaires and went out together as a thing, and that was it, but most people, they don't play it note for note, unless you're on a stage or something, then they will play it. But if you're on a dance job, they don't.

MR: Okay, so after World War II, did you stay on the east coast or did you eventually move out.

JB: I joined Benny Goodman immediately. I got out the 9th of October in 19 — what year was this?

MR: '44 was it?

JB: '45. And I went back to North Carolina to see my mother for a couple of days or something. But I had the job with Benny, I think the 15th or something like that. And I was with Benny until he broke up the band in fourteen months. And I was very happy to

join that band after three years in the Navy. Because four of us went out of that band. The band, we were not all, they discharged — the married guys got out first, they had more points. So they didn't know it but I was divorced at about that same time. If they'd have found out I'd probably still be in the Navy.

MR: You said something about points? You had to have a certain number of points?

JB: To get out.

MR: Okay. And if you were married—

JB: Overseas counted more than home. So we were overseas two out of the three years we were out of the country. You got a little more money, sixteen dollars a month or something, for travel time.

MR: Well when you joined Goodman, Gene Krupa was probably gone by then.

JB: Maurice, oh no, I can't — he died. Morey Feld.

MR: Oh Morey Feld.

JB: Well four of us joined, there was the bass player, Barney Kessel — not Barney Kessel — Barney Spieler, was our bass player. Later on he got killed in an auto accident in Holland, he had moved to Holland and was playing in a symphony there and he was killed. That was the bass player in the Navy band.

MR: We were talking about the Goodman trumpet section.

JB: Gozzo and I joined, well Benny, the trumpet section was Gozzo, Fozzo, Muchie and Best. And Benny says, "Gozzo, Fozzo, Mucho and Bozzo" I was going to be.

MR: You had to have a vowel at the end of your name to fit with everybody else.

JB: But that changed pretty fast. Benny went through a lot of different players in the fourteen months. And then that band broke up in New York at the 400 Club. Business just went to the — he took the band off the road. Benny had a guarantee of three thousand dollars a night, compared to Harry's guarantee — this for a dance. And people stopped going to dances. So Benny had a show with Victor, the comedian the piano player—

MR: Victor Borge?

JB: Victor Borge. For Sacony I think it was, which is centered all in New York. And played the 400 Club. Well the 400 Club, business was bad, and he said that he couldn't guarantee the payroll for the last — so I left the band in December of '46. I came to California. Then I had to sweat out the Los Angeles Musician's union card. Another six months you know. And I've been out in California since then.

MR: Can I ask you why, do you have an idea why people stopped dancing?

JB: Well there was kind of a revolution between the generations. One generation — it's happening again — this is the theory. Whatever your mother and father were listening to, they wanted no part of that. They revolted. And that was what affected us. Now, the rock stuff, the younger kids are starting to like that stuff that we did. I don't know if it's ever

going to amount to anything, but there was fifty-seven thousand going to hear the Rolling Stones at the Qualcomm, at sixty dollars a ticket, in the rain. That's still pretty big business.

MR: I guess so. So you moved out to the west coast.

JB: December of '46, yeah.

MR: You got into some broadcast work?

JB: Well you know you sweat out your six months card.

MR: Oh, same thing again, huh?

JB: At the end of that time I did a radio show. Television hadn't started then. A five day a week radio show with Bob Crosby, call the Club 15. It was a short program but it was five days a week. And that went for five and a half years. In the meantime you do recording too, with different groups. And somewhere along the line I bought an orchard, in San Diego county, which I kept that orchard until I broke my back.

MR: What did you grow there? Oranges?

JB: Avocados. Commercially you know. I don't recommend the area — 80 mile an hour winds are tough on agriculture.

MR: What caused you to want to get into something outside music?

JB: My ex-wife. She didn't like the music business at all. It made nothing but enemies, and she's too old to listen to this, so she wouldn't know it.

MR: Well after your accident, you were still able to play trumpet?

JB: Fortunately. I was lucky because Crosby, I started with him at Disneyland. I could get around quite a bit better then but a lot of things have happened since that original accident, that broke the left leg and tore up both shoulders, and no use — and I had surgery on the lip. That was a pretty big blow right there. But I still play. I like to play. I can't do what I used to.

MR: There's some guys around here who still like to play with you.

JB: What?

MR: There's some guys around here who still like to play with you. Bobby Gordon for one.

JB: Oh yeah. I did New Year's Eve with Bobby.

MR: When you look back on your career in music, would you say that there's a few years that you really look fondly on, because of the band you were in or just because of the success of the music at that time? What was your favorite years in the music career?

JB: Well that's tough. It would have to be I think more recent than the original three.

MR: No kidding.

JB: Because I've done, for about ten years my late wife and I put on jazz things right at a place called Little Bavaria. And there, we just took over the place and hired the musicians. Most of them were like Nick Fatool, Eddie Miller and Abe Most, and Abe

Lincoln the trombone player, and Bobby Gordon. All good jazz players, and that went on once a month for about ten years. And I think as far as — of course I was the leader, so I got to do what I picked. But working with Matty Matlock, who did a lot of recordings, and he used me on, those are the things that I'm glad I did because I can listen to those — they're not like the big organized bands, it's just a recording date, you do that and you don't play that, but Matty was a wonderful writer, arranger, a good clarinet player. And also Billy May. Billy May was probably my best friend in the whole music business. When I first came to Hollywood he gave me my first recording dates and we did the Time-Life series. I can remember when I was in Palma Valley, that's where the orchard was, I wasn't playing very much and Billy used to come down and he said "how's your lip?" or something like that. Well it wasn't too good, I said — I don't think I should have — because these dates are pretty hard. So for a while there I didn't think I was up to it. So he came down once and I was doing an ice show in San Diego, I was really working on it. So he says, "How's your lip?" I said, "Well I just did the ice show." "Well do you want to do some recording?" I said, "Yeah." So that's what it was with the Time-Life thing. And that thing went on for, well there were fifteen albums, copies, all these were copies of the original records you know. I started on the third album I think. But that lasted like maybe a couple of years.

MR: I think this music came from that.

[audio interlude]

MR: I believe I got that off the Time-Life recording.

JB: Sounds like Tex playing lead though.

MR: Let's see if we can figure it out. Maybe this is one of the originals.

JB: Of course they're copying note for note, whoever it is. That's why it sounds funny.

MR: That tune first came out, what, probably '39?

JB: '39 is when I joined the band. '39, '40. I can't think when Bobby — maybe later.

MR: Maybe we can tell now.

JB: It sounds a little strong for Bobby.

MR: Not him? I think I have it written down in the other room, where this comes from, so we'll have to look after we're done. So you did some reunion things in the '80's too, with the Miller band and Crosby?

JB: In the 80's. Yeah, we did something at the shrine, when Mrs. Miller was there, in the audience. And Ben Pollack was there. Billy May was conducting the orchestra. That's when he had Micky McMickle was on that, and I think Ray Anthony too, and there was another trumpet guy.

MR: I wanted to ask you about one thing that I read in a book by Bill Crow. It has jazz stories in it. And it said something about you guys were at a Holiday Inn somewhere and it had a

sign, Happy Hour All You Can Drink for a Dollar. Do you remember this thing? Do you remember what you said?

JB: Somebody said I said that.

MR: Did you say that?

JB: That wasn't me.

MR: Somebody said "give me two dollars' worth?" Right? All you can drink for a dollar, give me two dollars worth?

JB: I think Billy Butterfield is who said this.

MR: No kidding.

JB: But Crosby, I think he blamed me on that.

MR: Well I always like to check on these stories you know, because sometimes they don't come out exactly right when people print them.

JB: But I will confess, it's not mine originally.

MR: Okay.

JB: I got blamed for that. And I heard it was Billy.

MR: Well you're certainly a popular man in the San Diego area, because all I've been hearing for the last couple of days is people saying, "John Best might come here, and we've got to see him." And I know there's some folks waiting for you downstairs that I hope you have a good time seeing. And I've really enjoyed talking to you, and reminiscing. And I think you've seen some great times in the music, and you certainly made a big contribution to this music over the years. Would you do it all over again?

JB: I guess so. If I could correct a few things.

MR: Okay. Well I want to thank you again for coming today, and it's been a great pleasure for me.

JB: Thank you.

MR: On behalf of Hamilton College, thanks a lot.

JB: Thank you very much.